

In Defense of Street's Antirealist Solution

In *A Darwinian Dilemma for Realist Theories of Value*, Sharon Street challenges moral realists by positing that Darwinian theories of evolution present an inescapable dilemma that makes realism incompatible with natural science. In this paper, I will summarize Street's argument, discuss two objections to Street from Katia Vavova's *Evolutionary Debunking of Moral Realism*, and propose a way for Street to successfully defend her view against these objections. In Part I, I will summarize moral realism, the view Street argues against. In Part II, I will reconstruct Street's Darwinian Dilemma using Vavova's evolutionary debunking framework, which will provide context for the subsequent objections; additionally, I will address missing components of Vavova's reconstruction. In Part III, I will summarize and refute an unsuccessful objection to Street. In Part IV, I will present Vavova's Hope for Realists, which I believe to be the strongest objection to Street. In Part V, I will propose a way for Street to defend her Darwinian Dilemma against Vavova's Hope for Realists.

Part I: Moral Realism, as understood by Street

Street defines moral realism as follows: "there are at least some evaluative facts or truths that hold independently of all our evaluative attitudes" (Street, 110). Street emphasizes the adverb "all" as a major difference between the realist and the anti-realist lies. Antirealists and realists, she says, can agree that an evaluative truth can exist independently of whether someone personally makes that evaluative judgment. However, antirealists do not believe that some evaluative truth could exist independently of the *whole set* of our evaluative judgments. For realists, given that Hitler was a genocidal dictator, the view that "Hitler was morally depraved" is true regardless of all of our evaluative judgments on this matter, whereas antirealists believe the truth of this view exists because of the set of evaluative judgments we hold. Street opposes the realist view of independent evaluative truths, believing it is incongruent with our current understanding of evolution in natural science. She argues instead that antirealism, specifically constructivism, provides a superior, scientifically consistent explanation.

Part II: Street's Darwinian Dilemma

Street's Darwinian Dilemma begins with the assertion that evolution has influenced the contents of our evaluative judgments. She observes that while significant diversity of evaluative judgments exist across cultures and time, there appear to be patterns in our basic evaluative tendencies, such as valuing the survival of ourselves, our family members, and our offspring (Street, 115). The best explanation for why we hold this particular set of unifying basic evaluative tendencies is that they promote our survival and Darwinian natural selection causes us to adopt those judgments that promote our survival. Thus, it is likely that evolutionary forces influenced our basic evaluative tendencies, from which our full-fledged evaluative judgments developed.¹

If the realist accepts that our evaluative judgments are saturated by evolutionary influence, they must decide what relation exists between the independent evaluative facts they believe in and this evolutionary influence. For Street, this places the realist in either a deeply skeptical or a non-scientific position: if no relation exists, then our evaluative judgments are probably false because it would be an incredible coincidence if they happened to align with the truth; if some tracking relationship exists (i.e., evolution tracks moral truths), it is scientifically inferior to the adaptive link account, which posits that our basic evaluative tendencies developed because they were evolutionarily advantageous actions in the circumstances we encountered as early humans (Street, 134). She concludes that neither of these are desirable, whereas antirealism presents a much more logical position.

Formally, I limit my reconstruction to Street's "tracking horn" using Vavova's evolutionary debunking framework, because the subsequent objections I raise only target this horn.² Vavova claims an evolutionary debunking argument has three components: it must be empirically rooted on a claim about our beliefs' origins, targeted against realists'

¹ Street articulates a distinction between basic evaluative tendencies and full-fledged evaluative judgments to make this theory more consistent with evolution. Specifically, evolutionary forces directly shaped our basic evaluative tendencies, which are genetically heritable. Through further reflection upon these basic tendencies, we may develop diverse full-fledged evaluative judgments that are not heritable but indirectly shaped by evolutionary forces (Street, 118-119).

² Vavova justifies her dismissal of the "no relation" horn by arguing that it is not empirical or targeted: the no relation argument (that it is improbable for our belief system to be the truth if there is no tracking involved) is not evolutionarily based and could apply to any belief system, not just normative. This reasoning would thus lead to global skepticism, which is not what Street, nor any evolutionary debunker, intends.

moral beliefs only, and epistemologically arguing not that moral truths do not exist but that we cannot know them (Vavova, 2). Such an argument is stronger than a skeptical argument in providing reason to doubt, making the worry not just possible but probable. Vavova believes Street's tracking horn presents such a compelling argument for realists to doubt their views.

1. *Realism*: Moral truths are attitude-independent.
2. *Influence*: Evolutionary forces have influenced our moral beliefs.
3. *Off-track*: Evolutionary forces aim at fitness, not attitude-independent moral truths.
4. *Gap*: The fitness enhancing beliefs and the moral truths come apart.
5. *Mistaken*: We have good reason to think that our moral beliefs are mistaken.

(Vavova, 5)

Vavova finds this to be the strongest version of Street's argument, as Street empirically argues that taking a realist's stance makes it improbable that our moral beliefs are true.

Vavova's reconstruction of Street differs from Street's actual argument in a few aspects. First, Vavova no longer retains Street's argument structure; a more accurate representation of Street's paper would be to use a constructive dilemma reconstruction, which would directly compare the two horns. However, Vavova chooses not to use this structure because she believes only the tracking horn successfully acts as a debunking argument. In addition, Vavova doesn't explicitly articulate the tracking horn as Street does. Vavova captures the essence of Street's argument by acknowledging that the tracking account is inferior to the adaptive link account (*Off-track* premise). However, Vavova's *Gap* premise is not quite as obvious in Street's actual argument. Street argues that the more parsimonious adaptive link account does not require moral truths to exist; Vavova takes this one step further to argue that the adaptive link account (i.e. evolutionary forces aim at fitness) contributes to the *Gap* premise if operating in a realist framework where moral truths exist. Finally, Vavova ends her reconstruction in a different place from where Street ends her argument. Street goes one step beyond the *Mistaken* conclusion to propose an antirealist solution to the dilemma. Thus, the culmination of Street's argument is not to prove that we are probably mistaken, but to show why it is preferable to be antirealist.

Part III: Unsuccessful Objection to Street

One objection to Street is the third-factor account objection. This objection denies the *Gap* premise by claiming that although evolution does select for fitness, fitness correlates with moral truths, so our evolutionarily adapted evaluative judgments align with evaluative truths. For example, Wielenberg assumes that beings with advanced cognitive capacities have rights. Evolution has selected for us to have advanced cognitive capacities. These capacities are what enable us to believe we have rights. Thus, if we believe we have rights, then we do, so evolution has indirectly selected for us to be able to know moral truths (Vavova, 8).

The problem with this objection is that it is inherently question-begging: how can we assume these statements are moral truths? Wielenberg argues that it is unproblematic to assume the existence of moral truths, because the debunker's argument also does so.³ However, it is unclear that we can assume the specific contents of moral truths and assume specific statements, such as "human beings have rights," to be moral truths.

Part IV: Strongest Objection to Street

I believe the strongest objection to Street's argument is Vavova's Hope for Realists. Vavova attacks the *Gap* premise in Street's tracking horn by pointing out that, in asserting that there exists a gap between evolutionarily advantageous beliefs and moral truths, Street is making assumptions about moral truths, which is precisely what Street says a person cannot know.⁴ We can reconstruct Vavova's Hope for Realists:

1. Street claims that we cannot presume to know what moral truths are.
2. If moral truths can be about anything, then we have no idea if evolutionary forces push us towards or away from these moral truths.
3. We have no reason to think we are mistaken.

Vavova's Hope for Realists pinpoints the weakness in Street's jump to asserting that our evolutionarily developed beliefs are probably not tracking moral truths, because in fact Street cannot say anything about what moral truths exist. Thus, it is possible but no longer

³ The debunker relies on the existence of moral truths as the antecedent of this conditional statement: even if moral truths exist, we cannot know what they are.

⁴ Street's entire dilemma relies upon not knowing "where Bermuda is," or alternatively, what moral truths are, thus making it highly improbable that our moral beliefs would end up in alignment with the truth.

probable that evolutionary forces do not track moral truths. This, Vavova says, is no longer a strong debunking argument because it no longer provides sufficient reason for realists to doubt.

Part V: Street's Response

Street could argue that Vavova's reconstruction misrepresents the purpose of the Darwinian Dilemma by treating it as a debunking argument. Vavova's reconstruction ends with the Mistaken conclusion: that we have good reason to believe our moral beliefs are false due to a gap between evolutionarily advantageous beliefs and moral truths. Street would argue that her actual aim is different. Her conclusion is that in order to avoid the skeptical position of not knowing whether our moral beliefs are true, we ought to adopt a constructivist position. Thus, while Street's argument may have components of a debunking argument, it does not have the same goal, and Vavova is wrong to impose this structure upon Street. In particular, Street's argument does not depend upon the Mistaken conclusion as heavily as Vavova posits; in fact, Street could come to her constructivist conclusion even if she takes all of Vavova's Hope for Realists into account.

Street could charitably accept Vavova's point that, without making any assumptions about moral truths, it is possible that some of our moral beliefs are true (Hope for Realists). However, as both Street and Vavova acknowledge, this places us in a position of uncertainty where we lack the basis for determining which beliefs are true. This uncertainty is sufficient for Street to conclude that antirealism is a far more desirable stance; antirealism avoids this uncertainty without requiring assumptions about independent moral truths.

Furthermore, Vavova places the burden of proof upon Street, thereby sidestepping her responsibility to justify realism. In doing so, Vavova implicitly assumes a realist starting point that the evolutionary debunker must prove themselves against. However, if we truly begin with no assumptions about moral truths, then both Street and Vavova are "debunking" the opposing side and therefore both possess the burden of proof. Thus, Street could argue that 1. Vavova misconstrues her argument as an attempt to prove probability rather than possibility of error for realists, and 2. Vavova cannot escape her own burden of proof to justify her realist stance.

On this interpretation, Street's argument remains defensible against Vavova's objection. Street's conclusion is that we should take an antirealist, constructivist position because it is consistent with science without requiring assumptions about independent moral truths. Even if Vavova succeeds in showing that some of our moral judgments are true, her position still leaves uncertainty about which moral judgments might be true, which might not be, and how we could know. By contrast, Street's constructivist position offers a framework that avoids this epistemic problem, thus making it a more compelling alternative.

Works Cited

Street, Sharon. "A Darwinian dilemma for realist theories of value." *Philosophical studies* (2006): 109-166.

Vavova, Katia. "Evolutionary debunking of moral realism." *Philosophy Compass* (2014): 1-13.